

Pedestrian Advisory Committee Meeting Minutes

7:30 p.m. June 12, 2019 Brookline Town Hall

Members present: Frank Caro, Alison Pincus-Jacobs, Jane Ross, David Trevvett, John Schreffler, Robert Sloane. Not present: Adelaide Ketchum

Transportation Board Liaison present: Jonathan Kapust

Guests: Dan Martin, Brookline Department of Transportation; Ann Sussman (friend of Jane Ross); Collette Farnum-Vogt and Alex Vogt

(1) Topics not on the agenda

Alex Vogt and Colette L. Farland- Vogt, parents of a Brookline resident, raised questions about the intersection of St. Marys and Mountfort Streets. The first was that the signal timing is not good, and speaking for the local resident who passes the intersection daily on her route to work, would like change in timing to allow more time for pedestrians to cross Mountfort St., especially those with baby carriages, which must navigate curbs. The second issue is that there are only three of the corners of this intersection that have curb ramps installed, and that other three remain an obstacle for parents with carriages because of unusually high curbs without ramps.

Dan Martin explained two aspects of the intersection: first, that the traffic signals are not managed by Brookline, but rather by Boston, though the signals are located in and owned by Brookline. Second that MassDOT has a proposed redesign for the intersection which will be implemented at the same time as the reconstruction of the bridge over the Turnpike, which passes directly under the St. Marys St. approach to the intersection from the north. MassDOT has not yet set a date when the bridge will be rebuilt along with the intersection. There is an issue of the bridge being higher than the intersection, which causes some of the difficulty described, and which the design might mitigate.

Colette L. Farland- Vogt made a suggestion that Brookline's beautiful streets are often plagued by low-hanging trees which should be trimmed. Could volunteers be used to help trim trees that affect passage on sidewalks? Frank Caro responded that the Town has an on-line reporting system, BrookONline (<http://spot.brooklinema.gov/>) and responds quickly to such concerns, including sidewalks buckled by tree roots.

(2) Review of minutes of April and May meetings

April – approved

May – approved

(3) Walk Signal Project

David Trevvett reported that the Committee's Intersection Survey questions had been completed for 50 intersections in the Town, with 5 slated for construction and therefore not surveyed, and 19 left on which we needed to collect data. [Intersections along Beacon Street are counted as double intersections, for outbound and inbound sides, respectively, because of the median and the Green Line tracks.]

David turned to the discussion document he had circulated with examples of Pedestrian Walk Signal Programming issues and asked Dan Martin for responses to the questions raised. The first example considered was the Beacon-Hawes intersection – when outbound Beacon traffic is stopped, it would be safe for pedestrians to cross those outbound lanes, but there's a long 17-sec delay before the walk signal comes on. Dan explained that the walk phase is only tied to one vehicle

movement – it's a limitation of circuitry in the controller, not enough capacity in the back panel. East, west, and T traffic must all be stopped before the walk signal will come on. Committee members ask about upgrading the equipment to provide the desired functionality. Dan replied that it could cost \$2000 for a new controller, and another \$2000 to program it. (The town does not have in-house signal programming resources, but uses outside contractors.) Even with new controllers, Dan wasn't sure the problem would be solved. The Town's contractors are currently installing one of the latest controllers at Pearl Street and Brookline Avenue and having significant difficulty getting it to work. Committee members ask whether it might be feasible to have multiple controllers at a divided intersection such as those along Beacon; Dan did not think this could work, because the two sides of the median have to be coordinated.

Dan was asked whether there were other equipment manufacturers whose controllers might have greater capabilities. Dan explained that the Town tries to purchase all such equipment from a single manufacturer to simplify staff training and equipment repair, enabling the Town to keep spare parts on hand. Even if another manufacturer had better equipment, it would be difficult to change.

Committee members then asked whether any of the cited examples could be fixed with the existing equipment. After reviewing the examples, Dan cited several that might be possible to fix by reprogramming the existing equipment. Dan and David agreed to work after this meeting to come up with a list of those that could be managed with available equipment and programming resources.

Regarding the more difficult intersections, Dan suggested that we could write up descriptions of how we would like them to function, then send those descriptions to the controller manufacture and ask them if their equipment can do what we want. David and Dan will work together to prepare these examples. The Committee suggested using two examples - Hawes and Beacon as a T intersection and Beacon and St. Paul for a more standard intersection.

The costs of acquiring such equipment will also be needed, so that this Committee and the Town can visualize what might be necessary in terms of upgrading the controllers to handle pedestrian crossings better. When the committee can see potential costs, it will be useful guidance for further actions, such as requesting items to add to the Capital Improvement Program for the Town.

(4) Discussion of draft memo on school building projects planning process

A proposal for a joint memo from the Pedestrian Advisory Committee and the Bicycle Advisory Committee had been circulated prior to this meeting. The memo urged the Transportation Board to contact the School Committee, Planning Board, and other Town bodies to work together towards two goals: (a) expanding the scope of planning for school building projects to include safe biking and walking routes to school; and (b) arranging for the traffic study work to be scheduled so that there can be adequate time for consideration by and input from our advisory committees before Transportation Board consideration.

Following a brief discussion, the Committee voted affirmatively to authorize David Trevvett to work closely with the Bicycle Advisory Committee to finalize the memo and submit it to the Transportation Board for their earliest consideration.

(5) E-Scooter Pilot program

At the public meeting on the progress of the E-Scooter Pilot program in the Town, held in the hour before this Committee's meeting convened this evening, many community members (including a Pedestrian Advisory Committee member) testified that scooters should be prohibited from operating on sidewalks and that enforcement efforts should be strengthened to assure that

pedestrians would feel safe.. Others testified that liability issues had not been discussed, and that the evaluation process for the pilot was unexplained and that criteria for success of the program had not been defined.

Frank Caro noted that the BrooklineCAN Livable Community Advocacy Committee had held two meetings on electric scooters. He expressed dismay that the Police Department did not understand that the guidelines for operation of scooters were stricter than those for bicycles, and were instead treating the two the same way. Bicycles are permitted on sidewalks outside of commercial districts as long as they travel slowly at a normal walking speed, but scooters are not permitted on sidewalks at all.

(6) Beacon Bridle Path proposal

The Beacon Street Bridle Path proposal has engendered interest in the Town, with support coming from many organizations, and including attendees at the June 5th Sustainability Summit. Dan Martin affirmed that electric vehicular charging stations are being installed in the Beacon Street's median diagonal parking area that now uses the right-of-way for the bridle path. These stations could be a point of conflict in implementing the bridle path proposal. Dan indicated that the Town was trying to find a way to eliminate this conflict.

(7) Updates

The Transportation Board has approved the option for the Longwood-Harvard Street intersection that provides for no right turn from Harvard St. northbound onto Longwood.

The Board's chair negotiated a compromise to resolve the controversy on the proposed improvements to the Woodland-Heath Intersection by adding public discussions and agreeing to try the improvements without a flashing beacon and then examine whether one is needed for safety and should be added.

Town meeting has approved the proposed Parking Benefit District for Brookline Village, and the proposal to create a committee to develop a plan for pedestrian-friendly street lighting.

The Pedestrian Advisory Committee's next meeting will be July 10. It will be a regular meeting at Town Hall, not a walking meeting as previously discussed.

The meeting was ended at 9:21 p.m.

Notes prepared by Bob Sloane.